

100-YEAR HISTORY WALK

MATERINTY WING OF PETERBOROUGH SOLDIERS MEMORIAL HOSPITAL



A meeting was held on Friday 27th February 1891 to consider the advisability of providing hospital accommodation in the town of Petersburg. A further meeting was held on Monday 25th April 1892. As a result of that meeting a Hospital Fund was established and the residents began fundraising. In 1895 the hospital was closed at Waukaringa and it was hoped that the government would remove the weatherboard and iron building to Petersburg.

A meeting of subscribers to the Petersburg Hospital Fund was held on Friday 4th February 1898 and the mayor conveyed to the small gathering that correspondence from the Chief Secretary informed them that the government could not help the town in any way to erect a hospital.

The Mayor said that they had been informed by the Chief Secretary that the Government could not help them in the way of erecting a hospital. Personally, he (the Mayor) was pretty well tired of the hospital question. To have a local hospital would mean a very severe tax on the residents, as all the "lame and blind," &c. from the surroundings would be brought in to be attended to at their expense, and it would be an ill day for the residents when a hospital was erected. They would, he thought, be serving their own interests best, from every point of view, by taking advantage of either the Jamestown or Burra hospitals. As the former was the nearer one to Petersburg perhaps it would be as well to expend their money there, and he would suggest that a new Ward be built at Jamestown hospital to be called the Petersburg Ward, which could be always at their disposal. They should do their best to expend the funds in hand but of course they could not do anything in that direction without the consent of the Racing Club and other subscribers.

Mr Emery considered it would be a mistake to erect a hospital at Petersburg as by so doing they would not reap any benefit, directly or indirectly, but would only be heaping a heavy tax upon themselves. Even if they had sufficient funds in hand to erect a handsome building, there was the maintenance of same which would be a big item. Their funds, he thought, could be made better use of by handing them over to the Jamestown hospital. He moved—That, with the consent of the Racing Club, the money in hand be handed over to the Jamestown hospital or otherwise disposed of. In the event of it going to James' own the Board of Management be requested to erect a Ward there to be called the Petersburg Ward."

Mr Forgan considered they could not even build an isolation hospital without the consent of the racing club as the money was subscribed for a hospital. If the money could not be given to Jamestown he would sooner see it held over for twelve months. He moved as an amendment—"That matter, be held over for twelve months."

Petersburg Times
Friday 11 February 1898

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In July 1899 Victoria Jubilee Park was purchased by the council from the trustee Mr Rohde with the money from the Hospital Funds. The residents were led to believe that a hospital would be erected at the site of the park.

THE TOWN COUNCIL AND VICTORIA JUBILEE PARK. — The long-standing difficulty occasioned by the liability on the Park has been happily solved by the Town Council agreeing to purchase the same with the hospital trust funds as a site, presumably, for a local hospital. The amount to the credit of the Hospital Fund is about £6 short of the amount required to pay off the indebtedness on the Park and this sum Cr Degenhardt, who has taken a good deal of interest in the matter, volunteered to collect. The members of the Racing Club as the principal subscribers to the fund favored its utilisation for this purpose, and the action of the Town Council in the matter will, we think, meet with general approval, as it would have been a thousand pities had the Park reverted to a private owner.

Petersburg Times
Friday 9th June 1899

Some private residents operated as including Mrs Holland (Brady), Nurse Quinn and Nurse Lowry at 83 Victoria Street. She moved to the corner of Collins and Bourke Street in 1919. Several ran as a maternity hospital run by a midwife, one being located at 4 High Street. The state school was used several times as a temporary hospital when there had been an outbreak of influenza or other disease in the town.

Resident doctors offered consulting rooms at their premises. Dr Clarke consulted in Bismark Street, two doors west from the Baptist Church in 1912, before building his house and consulting rooms in Jervois Street in 1919. After the tragic death of Dr Clarke in 1922, Dr Schafer ran his practice from the Jervois Street premises, followed by Dr Morris in 1930, Dr Myers in 1944, Dr Webster in March 1958, Dr Bielby in September 1958 and Dr Shortt in 1966. Veterinarian Dr Tonuma purchased the property in December 1968. **Dr Goode in Railway Terrace**

A meeting was held on Wednesday 1st February 1911, convened by the mayor William Butterworth to urge upon the government the necessity of building a hospital in the town. The meeting was attended by a large number of ratepayers and the majority of those present felt that it was "*highly desirable that a hospital should be built for the district.*" - *Petersburg Times* – Friday 3 February 1911.

In 1913 the committee under the chairmanship of Dr C. Lowther Clarke obtained a promise of assistance from the government and fundraising began.

It was proposed at a meeting in May 1914 "*to raise a sum of £2,000 by public conscription, to which will be added the government subsidy of £3,000 and thus a total of £5,000 will be available for building and furnishing a hospital. The plans provided for a hospital of 20 beds.*" – *Daily Herald* – Tuesday 19 May 1914.

The fundraising was eased with the outbreak of war although £500 had been raised by donations and social occasions.

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Following the end of the war the desire to establish a hospital in Peterborough was rejuvenated and a committee headed by Dr Arthur Goode was elected in 1919. It was decided to build the hospital as a lasting and worthy memorial to our brave men who had fought in the war.

SA Chief Secretary JG Bice visited the town to open a fundraising fair for the hospital. Mr Bice was met at the station by Mayor SD Jones and Councillor SW Dickson and driven to the hospital site on six acres donated by Mr J Cochrane.

Tenders were called for the construction of the hospital and were due on Monday 1st March 1920. The plans and specifications had been completed and the hospital would be the most-up-to-date in the state.

Mr Haese of Jamestown was awarded the contract with his tender of £12,000.

The foundations for the Peterborough Soldiers Memorial Hospital had been laid on 20th August 1920 and the nurses quarters, infectious wards and kitchen block were almost complete. The foundation stone was laid by the Governor Sir Archibald Weigall on Tuesday 9th September. £4,000 had been raised but in order to open the hospital free of debt at least £2,000 more was required that year.

By August 1921 work was progressing and the grounds were coming along.

Peterborough Hospital.

Progress Report.

Water level has been reached in the well.

Mr. Edson has gone quietly on filling in the lawn.

Mr. Lehmann came along with his horse and dray Saturday and Monday, and did good work.

Mr. von Bertouch continues to improve the orchard.

Nearly two dozen new fruit trees, almonds, and vines have been planted this week.

Climbing roses have been placed around the lawn.

Mr. Ray Ayliffe, reported at the hospital grounds that he was leaving the town and would like to do some work on the hospital grounds first. He dug ten tree holes. God bless him.

Messrs Shakes, Chamberlain, and Berryman have started digging up the vegetable garden.

Mesdames Smallcomb and Lawry and Nurse McNeil, assisted by various young ladies, have planted hundreds of larkspurs around trees and shrubs to poison the grasshoppers if, and when, they come. Be careful please, when attending to these trees, not to disturb the young plants.

Five girls and two small boys are attending to the trees they planted, but what are these among so many?

Railway Terrace promises to provide enough beautiful soft loamy soil for the hospital grounds. Each householder is doing his little bit, and the corporation carts are removing the heaps of soil regularly (more or less). Within a week or two the whole street should be quite clean, and both hospital and town will benefit greatly.

The first rustic seat has been made by the mayor and his son.

Mrs. Phelan is working well for the big summer-house to be placed on the hill west of the hospital buildings.

Requirements.

There are 24 tree holes yet to be dug.

The lawn is not yet filled in and Mr. Edson's heart would be gladdened by a little help.

* There are heaps of stone to be barrowed off the orchard.

Manure and rubbish to be spread around the almond trees.

Stones to be cracked on the main road around the lawn.

Road levelling to be done.

Pine posts wanted.

Posts for cow yard (pine or gum).

Fantastically bent mallee to make rustic seats.

There is much work for many people—all can help.

100-YEAR HISTORY WALK

MATERINTY WING OF PETERBOROUGH SOLDIERS MEMORIAL HOSPITAL

The opening of the hospital was unduly delayed and a further £1,000 was needed to open the hospital free of debt.

PETERBOROUGH **Soldiers' Memorial Hospital.**

Owing to circumstances, over which the Hospital Committee have had no control, the opening day has been unduly delayed.

Happily, however, we are able to announce that the last of construction and furnishing is now well in hand, and the opening of the Hospital will take place very shortly.

It has always been our aim to construct and equip an institution of which the District generally and every individual helper might well be proud.

The airy, well lighted wards, fitted with mosquito proof screens and dark blinds, with their wide doors opening on to magnificent verandahs, the hot and cold water service, and water flush sanitary service baths constitute almost an invitation to get ill.

The X-ray outfit is installed and working, and appliances are being installed for the conversion of the electric current installed into other forms of electricity for medical and surgical use.

Comfortable housing for employees has been a feature of the plans, and this is being expanded and amplified, under the personal supervision of Matron Bell, who has arrived and is helping with final arrangements.

The well and irrigation system are working, the cow shed, haystack, poultry yard and duck pond are accomplished facts and the caretaker's house well on the road to completion.

The fruit trees in the orchard are vigorous and healthy and the lucerne, planted a few months back, growing well.

The desire of the Committee is that milk, eggs, poultry and vegetables shall be as far as possible, our own produce.

FINANCE.

Money raised in and around district, £6,310; Government subsidy collected, £7,814; total amount spent, £13,250; total liabilities, about £4,000.

There is ample Government subsidy set aside on the estimates to cover the liability, provided we raise our quota, viz. £1 to each £1 10s of subsidy.

To raise £1,000 will enable us to do what has never been done in South Australia before, that is **open the Hospital free of debt.**

Enthusiasm for this ideal is growing—please help to spread it!

Just think! A hospital! Our chosen Soldiers' Memorial, costing approximately £17,000, opened free of debt!

What a second business proposal!

How essentially economic!

What a grand ideal!

Are there 100 £10 notes between Yongala and Cockburn, between Erskine and Dawson, and Terowie?

Everybody should be in this.—Everyone be able to say, "I helped to launch our Hospital

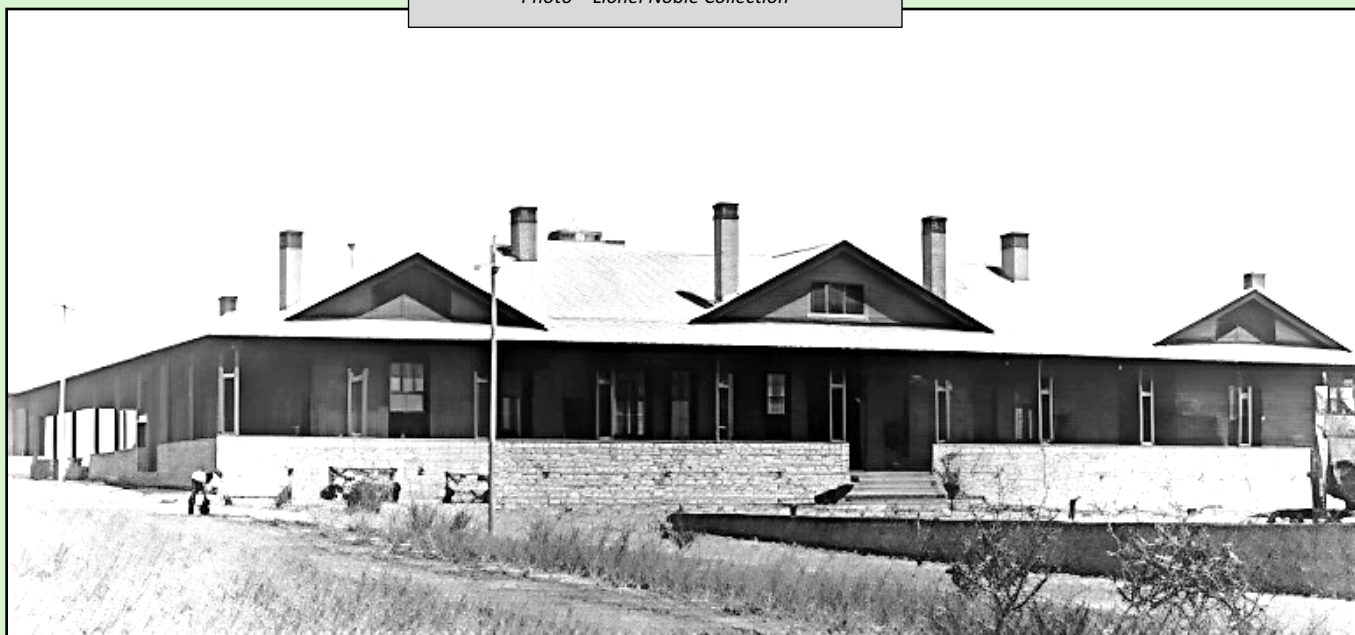
FREE OF DEBT."

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The opening of the Peterborough Soldiers Memorial Hospital was held on Wednesday 5th April by the Chief Secretary and Acting Premier (the Hon J.G. Bice in inclement weather. The school children assembled outside the gateway and marched to the lawn and the Returned Soldiers assembled under the main entrance steps. The opening was performed by the Chief Secretary and Acting Premier (The Hon. J. G. Rice). The hospital was then thrown open for public inspection, guided by staff. Afternoon tea was then served on the grounds. A carnival was held in the Town Hall in the evening and was a great success with a further £450 raised.

The hospital opened completely debt free and was the most up to date in the state. The people of Peterborough were to be congratulated for the fundraising effort they put in to built the hospital.



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By 28th April there were 18 patients under treatment at the hospital.

The residents of Peterborough continued to support the hospital with many giving a variety of donations including meat (rabbits, chickens and sheep), cream and butter, cakes, vegetables, eggs, sauce, pickles, chutneys, flowers, wood, magazines, papers, books, clothes and linen.

Dr Clarke had plans to increase the accommodation for the nursing staff and following his tragic death in September 1922 the hospital board continued with fundraising for the additions.

A large gathering assembled at the hospital grounds on Saturday 24th November 1923 for the opening of the new nurses quarters in memory of the late C. Lowther Clarke, and unveiling of the memorial plaque. The building had been completed at a cost of £1,150 of which £150 remained to be raised. The new building was situated behind the other nurses' quarters at the rear of the hospital and consisted of six rooms, passage right through both ways and surrounded by wide verandas, which may be used for sleeping out.

In April 1925 the returned soldiers club sold its premises as members could no longer support its overdraft and the guarantor wished to be free of liability. A vote of 23 to five confirmed the club's closure and sale proceeds were donated to the hospital in return for which veterans were given free treatment.

There was a great need for a maternity ward at the hospital. There was no baby welfare centre here and maternity cases could not be taken in the general hospital on account of lack of space and the noise, which would not be beneficial to other patients. Children under the age of two were not admitted to the hospital for the same reason. *"The town was served by 3 or 4 well kept homes, providing accommodation for about 16 patients, but even these were not certain of continuing, as the nurses were anxious to close their homes."* *The Times* – Friday 22 May 1925.

The residents of Peterborough again started fundraising with many events held to raise money. The Nelia orchestra held a dance in the town hall, a Queen competition was held raising £887 and the hospital fete raised over £1,000.

Despite the wet and cold a large crowd assembled at the Hospital Grounds on Friday 21st August 1925 to witness Mrs John Gunn, wife of the Premier, lay the foundation stone for the new maternity wing. Mr Alex Jamieson, (Chairman of the Hospital Board) presented Mrs Gunn with a silver trowel in honour of laying the stone.

The Maternity Block of the Peterborough Hospital was opened on Friday 12th February 1926 by the Premier (Hon John Gunn).

After an official inspection the premier (Mr Gunn), chairman of the board (Mr Alex Jamieson), the mayor (Mr William Reed), invited guests, members of the hospital board, councillors and hospital staff assembled on the front veranda for the opening. The school children and fife band marched to the hospital and sang 'The song of Australia' before Mr Jamieson welcomed the visitors. The maternity wing was named the "Mother's Wing" and he felt that no better name could have been chosen.

Mr Gunn congratulated the residents of Peterborough on their very fine achievement in erecting the maternity wing. The people of the town and district had raised £5,600 including £3,000 from the proceeds of entertainment. The government had contributed a subsidy for a total of £16,000.

PETERBOROUGH HOSPITAL.

A MATERNITY WING.

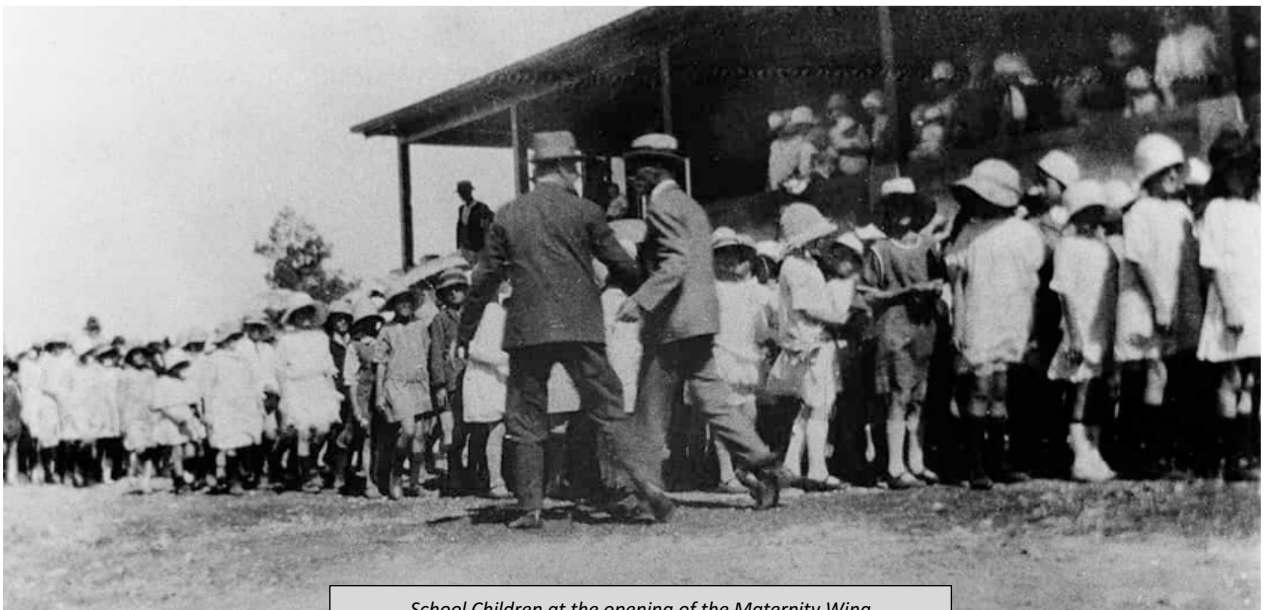
OPENED BY THE PREMIER.

Peterborough, February 12.

A large crowd assembled at the hospital to take part in the opening of the new maternity block this afternoon. The Premier (Hon. J. Gunn) and other visitors were met at the train by the chairman and members of the Hospital Board, the mayor and councillors, and motored to the scene.

The new building measures 140 ft. in length and is 70 ft. wide, including a 9 ft. verandah in front, two 9 ft. enclosed side verandahs, a 9 ft. corridor from side to side, running east and west, six private rooms, two three-bed wards, two bed isolation wards, and fly-proof side verandahs capable of accommodating twelve waiting patients when necessary. The building is of rough freestone, very lofty and airy, and the front verandah floor is 4 ft. from the ground. All the latest appliances are provided for the operating room, and the structure includes a dining-room, kitchen, sitting-room, electric equipment, sanitary accommodation, septic tank, &c. Outside there are a large underground tank (48,000 gallons) and overhead tanks. A hot and cold water service is provided throughout the buildings. The total cost of the building, including the equipment, was £8,000. Nurses' quarters and night nurses' quarters are also provided. The total cost of the hospital buildings now aggregates between £25,000 and £30,000. The maternity block is separate from the hospital, but will be under the control of the general matron (Miss J. Bell), with Miss E. Neil in charge of the maternity as obstetrical sister.

The Chronicle
Saturday 20 February 1926



School Children at the opening of the Maternity Wing
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection

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In early 1926 the maternity block was registered as a training school in midwifery and many hundreds of training midwifery and general nurses trained at the hospital throughout the following years. By 1928 no probationary nurse or midwifery trainee was engaged unless educational requirements of the South Australian Nurses Registration Board had been met and certificated had been produced. They also had to be approved by a committee.

In August 1930 the Nurses Registration Board requested that 75 percent of nurses employed at the Peterborough Hospital were partly-trained nurses. The Hospital Board were willing to engage 25 percent of partly trained nurses.

In 1949 the hospital was in desperate need of trained nurses and there was a thought that the hospital would have to be closed.

The Times
Friday 14 January 1949

Staff Shortage May Close Hospital
PETERBOROUGH, May 15.
A desperate staff position has arisen at the Peterborough Soldiers' Memorial Hospital. One trained nurse has notified her intention to leave, and with only three trained nurses remaining instead of the complement of 10, the present staff is being worked to exhaustion.
It is feared that unless help is forthcoming immediately the hospital will have to close.
A double certificated nurse and seven trainees are urgently required.

The Times
Friday 16 May 1954

HOSPITAL STAFF WANTED **Trained Nurses Needed Urgently**

There is an acute shortage of trained staff at Peterborough Hospital and it is urgently necessary to obtain relief for the overworked Matron. If any of our readers have friends who are either double or single certificated nurses they will be doing a good service to our local health body by asking them to come to Peterborough to work permanently or even for a short period until other relief is available.

If trained staff is not forthcoming it will be imperative to restrict the number of patients in the hospital or ultimately to close down the institution altogether.

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The unsatisfactory conditions of the nurses and domestic quarters were discussed in 1945. They were short staffed and advertised for four domestics to relieve the arduous duties of the nurses.



*Nurses at the Maternity Block*  
*Jean Giles (nee Quinlan) second from right*  
*Photo – Sue Giles*



*Peterborough Soldiers Memorial Hospital and Maternity Wing 1927  
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection*

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### MATERINTY WING OF PETERBOROUGH SOLDIERS MEMORIAL HOSPITAL

A public meeting was called on 16<sup>th</sup> June 1927 by the mayoress Mrs R.W. Goudie at the invitation of the board of management of the Peterborough Hospital, with the object of starting a Peterborough and District woman's auxiliary. The object of the auxiliary would be 'to assist in the welfare of necessitous cases among patients, to co-operate and assist the board of management of Peterborough Hospital in repair and upkeep of hospital linen, and to render aid in any other welfare matter they may deem necessary.' – *The News* – Monday 13 June 1927.

**PETERBOROUGH S.M.  
HOSPITAL.**

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**WOMEN'S HOSPITAL  
AUXILIARY.**

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Following upon the announcement that the Mayoress (Mrs. R. W. Goudie) and a small committee of representative ladies held a preliminary meeting with the object of inaugurating a Peterborough and District Women's Hospital Auxiliary, a general meeting of ladies took place in the lodge room, Town Hall, Peterborough, on Thursday, 16th June, 1927, and was largely attended by the ladies of the town. Mrs. Goudie was in the chair, and the Mayor (Mr. E. Hoile) and medical officer (Dr. C. H. Schafer) were in attendance, and outlined the scope of such an organisation as it was contemplated forming. Much enthusiasm was shown by those present who included Mesdames R. W. Goudie, E. A. Rowe, M. T. Groves, R. F. Cox, S. D. Jones, N. D. Keats, P. Prince, W. Erke, J. English, F. J. Snood, G. Battersby, Smallacombe, I. J. Bills, P. J. Martin, C. V. Hoile, W. E. A. Nankivell, A. A. Condell, C. H. Schafer, S. Lewis, W. McGlashan, S. B. Forgan, W. H. Bennett, Miss Ferguson and Miss Hunter. Apologies were received from Mesdames W. C. Reid, P. A. Wisewould, Chas. Reed, F. E. Sharley and Geo. Philp.

Mrs. Goudie was elected President Mesdames C. H. Schafer, E. A. Rowe and S. D. Jones, Vice-Presidents; Miss Hunter, treasurer; and Mrs. S. B. Forgan, secretary.

The objects (to assist in the welfare of necessitous cases amongst patients to co-operate with and assist the board of management of the Peterborough Soldiers' Memorial Hospital, Incorp in repair and upkeep of hospital linen etc.; to render aid in any other welfare matter they may deem necessary) were unanimously accepted by the meeting.

It was decided to hold meetings and work afternoons on the first Thursday of every month, with the first meeting on July 7th. This meeting will be held at the hospital at 3 p.m. and not in the lodge room, as advised at meeting. The President (Mrs. R. W. Goudie), treasurer (Miss Hunter), and secretary (Mrs. S. B. Forgan) were appointed a committee to confer with the matron of the hospital on various matters of interest to the auxiliary.

It is sincerely hoped that all ladies of the town and district will join the auxiliary, even though they may not be able to attend meetings, but at the same time a most cordial invitation is extended to all ladies to attend and enquiries to the secretary (Mrs. Forgan) re membership will be welcomed. It is anticipated that the auxiliary will fill a long-felt want in the town and district, and we wish it every success.

*The Times*  
Friday 24 June 1927

The Peterborough and Districts Citizens' Hospital Insurance Fund was launched in January 1927. The fund was similar to the Railway Workers Hospital Bed Fund and covered members for hospital treatment and expenses during illness, with special consideration for families. The fund began operation on 1<sup>st</sup> July with Mr W.H. Bennett appointed chairman and Mr M.E. Cope secretary.

By October 1927 the daily patient average for the hospital was 20 and the maternity hospital four.

The Peterborough and Districts Citizen's Hospital Insurance Bed Fund joined the SA Citizen's Bed Fund in 1931 which offered cover for hospital expenses anywhere in the state.

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